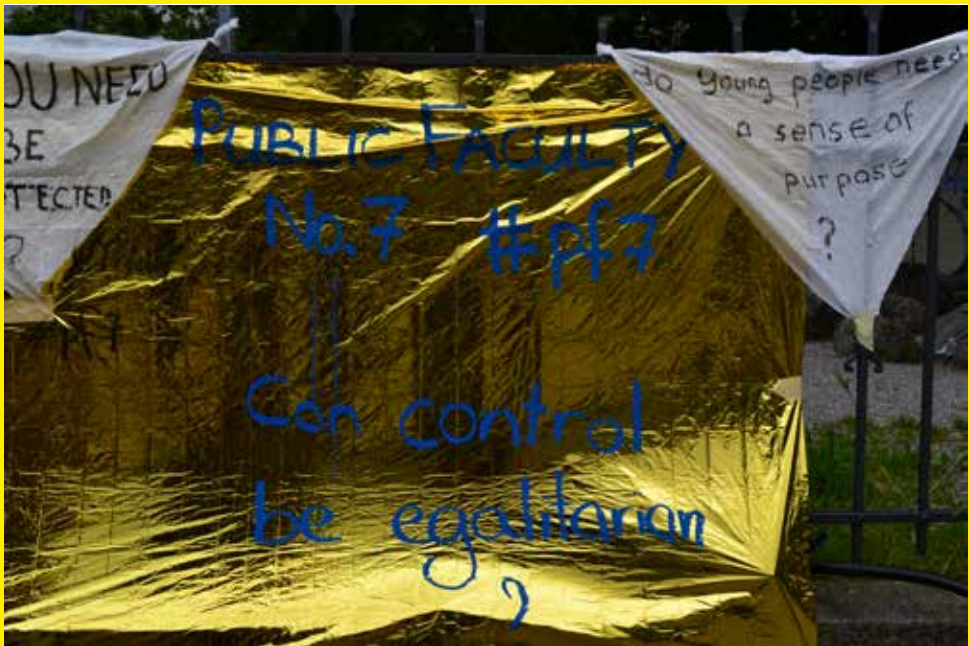

Dorothee Richter

**Curating: Politics of Display,
Politics of Site, Politics of Transfer
and Translation, Politics
of Knowledge Production**
A Fragmented and Situated Theory
of Curating



2.3 Curating from a Feminist Perspective

What would this mean for an anti-hegemonic kind of curating, as a special form of knowledge production? Curating is a gendered form of knowledge production: therefore, what would make a curatorial project a feminist one? I came to the conclusion that four categories need to be met:

Categories for Feminist Curating

1. The first category should be considering gender equality in terms of numbers in exhibitions and curatorial projects. I remember that this demand was thoroughly discussed because of the problem of reproducing a simplistic notion of “male” and “female.” We as feminists always fought for a multiplicity of sexes, beyond the binary code of a conventional paradigm. “Normal sexuality is thus, strictly speaking, an ordering, which the hysterics deny (then becoming sick),”⁶⁰ as Jacqueline Rose, following Lacan, has put it. This would mean that it would be a feminist project in art if one could infer from it the ordering of gender, as well as the difficulty or impossibility of this adjustment process, and also make it possible to identify the fictitious category of normal sexuality. This would distinguish an art that criticises and unsettles existing gender roles from an art that, in a proxy function, affirms “sexual fulfilment” while at the same time cementing an ordering of gender. A conventional affirmative art would basically conceal the splitting of the subject, to make it possible to see entire bodies and idealized images. A critical, feminist, potent art would reveal the splitting of the subject of the gaze; it would have no stress-relieving function. However, also derived from a Lacanian perspective, it is important to be aware of the position of “women” in patriarchy; “women” are denied a subject position insofar as the only possible subject position is that of the dominant male position, of the one who has the phallus. So, however creatively we play with gender roles, stealing the subject position by mimicking “male” behaviour or appearance, we should be aware of the mimicry and nevertheless still make a demand from the perspective of lack, from the position of the negated subject. I would, as a political demand, still adhere to the counting of numbers of men and women, especially when in the artistic field—in curating, exhibition-making, art, and universities—the imbalance is still in full bloom, or to put it differ-

60 ——— Rose, *Sexualität im Feld der Anschauung*, 57.

ently, as long as white men hold most of the top positions in universities, in ranking lists of the art market, and in institutional jobs. Where there is still an urgent need for the masked Guerrilla Girls! Therefore, I think that the demand for equality of representation has to be maintained, seeing this as a temporary strategy, a support structure on the way to diversity and multiplicity beyond fixed categories as a horizon.

2. The second category would be citing historical references correctly. This means referring to the movements, not to the singled out artistic geniuses, or stars—a paradigm which the art market prefers. This means in our context seeing the revolutionary movements of the '60s like Fluxus, Happenings, *Womanhouse*, and other feminist group works embedded in a struggle for new forms of communities, new forms of working together, new forms of meaning production/organisation that would be later called curating.



Bici Forbes-Hendricks und Geoffrey Hendricks, *Fluxdivorce*, 1971, as part of a social reconfiguration of the “*dispositif* of sexuality”

This means staying with the questioning of paradigms, like authorship, modes of production, new forms of distribution, and reception. These forms had in mind a specifically changed interrelation between audience and artists, between participants and producers, between high and low cultural production, between “races,” and, last but not least, between the relations of gendered roles. These transgressive practices from the past are always in danger of being connected back to one author or one artist, which limits their potential revolutionary approach in production, distribution, and reception. For contemporary curating, it means keeping to the approach of transgressive practices, creating new forms referring to archives, community-based projects, concept exhibitions, meeting spaces, and interventions in the public space, and acknowledging historical forerunners and initiatives in their complexities.⁶¹

3. The third category would be disturbance through the image, through the display. That does not mean, of course, that I see an exhibition as an integrated work of art; it is a specific, very complex narrative. Therefore, disrupting an easy narrative would be an important mission. According to Jacqueline Rose, Freud “relates—quite explicitly—the failure to depict the sexual act to bisexuality and to a problem of representational space. [...] A confusion at the level of sexuality brings with it a disturbance of the visual field.”⁶² Jacques Lacan differentiates the potential disturbance or calming which can result from art or painting. He sees the mode and manner of an artist in the desire to become visible as an author, to be a subject, to convey in the individuality of style something that gives the viewer the impression of being looked at from within the picture: “Thus they will see in the end, as in a filigree, something so specific for each of the painters that they feel the presence of the gaze.”⁶³ The gaze is understood here as the disturbing, unsettling moment, the recognition of being viewed from the outside.

If this concept is transferred to an exhibition, one might say that in curatorial work the production of meaning can give rise to an encounter that looks at the viewer. In some opposite cases, however, certain paintings or exhibitions assume the function of something for the eye to feed on, by which the visitor can lay down his/her gaze (like weapons). This would provide the pacifying, Apollonian effect of painting, which Lacan calls the

61 ——— This is why we (Ronald Kolb and I) published the film *Flux Us Now: Fluxus Explored with a Camera* with eleven chapters, one of which refers specifically to gender in Fluxus; it follows up on some of the political agendas of Fluxus and emphasises the complexity and the contradictions of the movement. See www.fluxusnow.net.

62 ——— Rose, *Sexualität im Feld der Anschauung*, 229.

63 ——— Jacques Lacan, “Linie und Licht,” in *Was ist ein Bild?*, ed. Gottfried Boehm (Munich: Brill Fink, 1994), 70.

“*dompte-regard*,” or the tamed gaze. The project *Female Coalities* (which I curated in 1997) emphasised this taming effect of the visual, but also of an author’s name. The artists Isolde Look, Irmgard Dahms, and Anne Schlöpcke invited Barbara Bloom, Cindy Sherman, and Kiki Smith and put children’s stuffed animals in an auction with a professional auctioneer in a gallery in Bremen, which sold off most of the items, and the sold animals were replaced with a polaroid of the owner with it.⁶⁴ The purchase prices often related to the fame of the respective artist.

This eye trap, with its pacifying effect, is revealed by the artists in the abovementioned project. This disturbing element would therefore also be unsettling and would call into question the normative ideology of *race*, *class*, and *gender*.⁶⁵ Contemporary theoreticians, here Denise Ferreira da Silva, imply the relationship between concepts of property and of individuality, to accelerated surveillance capitalism: “That thing with property, that is, the juridic-economic figure taking precedence over any alternative description of existence is not, however, self-sufficient. For it has always depended on colonial juridic-economic architectures and the

64 ——— Exhibition at Gallerie Cornelius Herz, Bremen, in the framework of the project *female coalities*, curated by Dorothee Richter, 1996.

65 ——— See also Dorothee Richter, “In conversation with False Hearted Fanny, Feminist Demands on Curating,” in *Women’s: Museum. Curatorial Politics in Feminism, Education, History, and Art* | *Frauen: Museum. Politiken des Kuratorischen in Feminismus, Bildung, Geschichte und Kunst*, ed. Elke Krasny (Vienna: Löcker Verlag, 2013), 75-83.



Exhibition in the framework of *Female Coalities* curated by D. Richter, artists: Isolde Look, Irmgard Dahms, Anne Schlöpcke with Barbara Bloom, Cindy Sherman and Kiki Smith, Galerie Cornelius Hertz, Bremen, 1996

racial ethnic-symbolic arsenal, improvement itself, the quality and capacity said to distinguish has also always being contingent upon our impropriety.”⁶⁶ One way to imply resistance is to ridicule the holy author function in the art field. I also suspect that the once-hyped notion of “the curatorial” might work as an “(eye) trap.” The notion of “the curatorial” implies a problematic ennoblement of curating as a meaning producing activity which takes place (as I see it) in a politically and ideologically contested field. Putting “curating” on eye level with philosophy, it is in danger of asking for essentialist, supra-temporal meaning production from curating, which would function outside of history. Instead, I would propose staying with re-contextualising, historicising, localising, and being aware of the political demands and alliances. Feminist curating can only be understood as a part of a political movement.

4. Institutional critique: to transfer this to exhibitions would mean always calling into question the context of the exhibition, using curatorial methods to unsettle the curatorial authorship of an exhibition’s discourse on truth and “quality” discourse. This means, from a feminist perspective, institutional critique should be embedded in projects. This would, of course, mean that any hierarchical positioning between curator and artists must be questioned. As types of naturalisation effects in art institutions, Oliver Marchart—citing the museum as an example—singles out four components that each have a gender-specific aspect: firstly, the power to define, which claims that the art institution is a neutral agency of mediation and judgment, is presented as being natural; secondly, the exclusions and inclusions, which make people forget that there are always very specific exclusions; thirdly, the constraints of cultural policy, budget, and similar factors to which the institution itself is subject; and fourthly, its class-based character.⁶⁷ The behavioural norms and built-in ideological concepts that, as subtexts, structure art institutions derived from the interests of a specific group, of which the paradigmatic representative is the white, male, middle-class subject. In the post-Fordist era, however, a clear classification like this has begun to undergo a shift, given that in the production process the subject is downgraded in favour of group processes. This makes it possible to speculate, for instance, that the middle-class subject is in retreat, as Felix Ensslin has remarked.⁶⁸

⁶⁶ ——— Denise Ferreira da Silva, Foreword to Stefano Harney and Fred Moten, *All Incomplete* (Colchester; New York; Port Watson: Minor Compositions, 2021), 7–8.

⁶⁷ ——— Oliver Marchart, “Die Institution spricht,” in *Wer spricht? Autorität und Autorschaft in Ausstellungen*, eds. Beatrice Jaschke, Charlotte Martinez-Turek and Nora Sternfeld (Vienna: Turia & Kant, 2005), 39f.

⁶⁸ ——— Felix Ensslin, on the occasion of my lecture on artistic authorship at the Kunstakademie Stuttgart, Dec. 2015.

Nachdenken statt Herrschen

Richter fordert feministische Gesten beim Konzipieren von Ausstellungen

Kuratoren hat in den letzten Jahren einen Siegeszug angehen lassen, den Kunstbetrieb hin- und her, das etwas auf sich haben, sondern gleich sein. Kuratoren jetten – ändern – von einer schillernden Rolle zur nächsten, in kreativen Flows. Die neue Rolle der „Neuen Geister“ zum Ausdruck, zieht Richter, Leiterin des Programms in Curating an der Hochschule der Künste, im Vortrag an der Hochschule die französischen Politiken und Eve Chia-Alt, die als „projektba-“turiert sei, verspreche Anerkennung und Ge-erfolg. Das Credo der-zeit, mobil und kreativ. Die Linie mit Harald-It der documenta 5 die-ten Kuratoren“ etablier-e zentrale Figur des- markts, Hans-Ulrich-ale Kuratorensubjekt: und vielfältig einsetz- Kurators erfahre mit- von männlicher Ge- iarchale Aufwertung.



WILL RÄUME DER REFLEXION SCHAFFEN: Dass Kunst soziale Bewegungen in ihrer Diskurs aufnimmt, soll laut Dorothee Richter in Ausstellungen sichtbar sein. Foto: Späti

False Hearted Fanny and myself, lokal newspaper, Karlsruhe, 29 May 2015

Institutional critique also means that, from a feminist-political perspective, all behavioural patterns are in question as well, all conventions and structures. This is why in some of my talks “False-Hearted Fanny” inter-feres, demonstrating the multi-layeredness of any discourse; she does not feel bound to institutionalised behaviour patterns and tends to show a sub-ject as a split subjectivity. To take into account the structural and material side of curating means—again—thinking of feminist curating as involved in and part of political and economic struggles. Thinking of curating as a form of producing knowledge or, in other words, of interpellations, means consciously taking up a position in an ideologically contested space. Individual museum presentations and their underlying ideological frame-works have been discussed and convincingly analysed in detail by Mieke Bal,⁶⁹ Jana Scholze,⁷⁰ Anna Schober,⁷¹ and also (jointly) by Gerlinde Hauer, Roswitha Muttenthaler, Anna Schober, and Regina Wonisch,⁷² to mention

⁶⁹ ——— Mieke Bal, “Telling, Showing, Showing off,” *Critical Inquiry* 18 (1992): 556–94.

⁷⁰ ——— Jana Scholze, *Medium Ausstellung. Lektüren musealer Gestaltung in Oxford, Leipzig, Amsterdam und Berlin* (Bielefeld: Transcript, 2004).

⁷¹ ——— Anna Schober, *Montierte Geschichten. Programmatisch Inszenierte His-torische Ausstellungen* (Vienna: Dachs Verlag, 1994).

⁷² ——— Gerlind Hauer, Roswitha Muttenthaler, Anna Schober, and Regina Wonisch, *Das Inszenierte Geschlecht. Feministische Strategien im Museum* (Vienna: Böhlau, 1997).

only a few. And during the writing and rewriting process of this publication, the notion of “institution” and of “art as institution” became increasingly important. I will address the problem of “institution” and “instituting” later.



Bici Forbes-Hendricks und Geoffrey Hendricks, *Fluxdivorce*, 1971

Dorothee Richter's argument understands curating or the curatorial not as a philosophical concept but as a practice that is deeply involved in the politics of display, politics of site, politics of transfer and translation, and regimes of visibility. It is based on a concept of critical research that takes as its starting point the investigation of what is often the overly simplistic understanding of the curator as a new agent in the fields of art and culture. Richter understands the curatorial as a multi-authored approach to the production of meaning, which is intrinsically linked to transformations of contemporary societies, the reorganisation of labour, cultural policies, politics of inclusion/exclusion, and issues posed by points of intersection.

Curatorial practice and theory have been developed in the context of cultural analysis, theories of power, and theories of communities based on feminist, queer, postcolonial, ecological, post-Marxist and other political and emancipatory positions. Many of these positions emerge out of political struggles or social movements. Ideally, curatorial knowledge production can be seen as a space for the negotiation of social, political, cultural, and economic conflicts. It understands curating as agency from which new constellations emerge. These could be represented in the format of an exhibition but equally in other forms of meaning production through a context-related media conglomeration, which involves a critical review of contemporary curatorial practices and theories. By engaging with these trajectories, the conditions and the foundations of knowledge production in the curatorial field become the subject of critical research leading to their re-positioning.

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